



The Dead Sea

An extremely salty Middle Eastern lake, with rapidly receding shorelines marking Earth's lowest point on dry land



△ SHORELINES OF THE PAST

Concentric terraces shows how the shorelines of the Dead Sea have receded over time. As the water levels continue to fall, and the lake shrinks, it becomes saltier.

A landlocked salt lake on the border between Israel and Jordan, the Dead Sea sits in a depression, called a graben, between two tectonic plates in the Jordan Rift Valley. At around 1,410 ft (430 m) below sea level, its

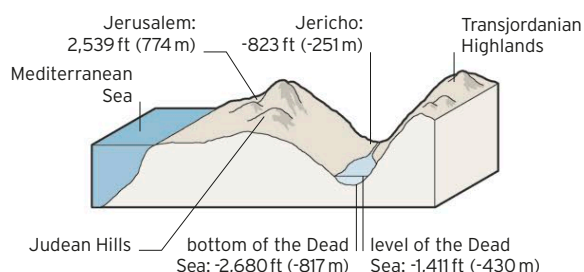
shores are the lowest point on Earth's land surface. With a salinity of about 35 percent—up to 10 times that of typical ocean water—the Dead Sea is one of the saltiest bodies of water on Earth and so can support very few life forms, hence its name.

▽ SALT SUPPLY

Crystallized salt is found all over the shores of the Dead Sea. Salt from the lake has long been valued for its culinary and medicinal uses.

THE ELEVATION OF THE DEAD SEA

The low elevation of the Dead Sea is due to its position between two tectonic plates. A lake first formed when the land to the west rose up and cut it off from the Mediterranean Sea. As the plates moved apart, the floor of the lake gradually dropped to a level below that of the sea.



Shrinking sea

The Dead Sea is mainly fed by the Jordan River, and although it has no outflow, in recent years its surface level has fallen rapidly, largely due to water diversion for commercial use. Receding shorelines have caused the lake to become separated into two basins by the extension of what was previously the Lisan Peninsula. The southern basin has since been divided into a series of evaporation pools for the extraction of salt.



The **level** of the Dead Sea is **dropping** by **more than 3 ft (1 m)** a year